Kernel Debugging



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Preventing bugs



Static code analysis

- Static analysis can be run with the *sparse* tool
- *sparse* works with annotation and can detect various errors at compile time
  - Locking issues (unbalanced locking)
  - Address space issues, such as accessing user space pointer directly
- Analysis can be run using `make C=2` to run only on files that are recompiled
- Or with `make C=1` to run on all files
- Example of an unbalanced locking scheme:

```
rzn1_a5psw.c:81:13: warning: context imbalance in 'a5psw_reg_rmw' - wrong count
  at exit
```

SPARSE



Good practices in kernel development (1/2)

- When writing driver code, never expect the user to provide correct values. Always check these values.
- Use the WARN_ON() macro if you want to display a stacktrace when a specific condition did happen.
  - dump_stack() can also be used during debugging to show the current call stack.

```
static bool check_flags(u32 flags)
{
  if (WARN_ON(flags & STATE_INVALID))
    return -EINVAL;
  return 0;
}
```



Good practices in kernel development (2/2)

- If the values can be checked at compile time (configuration input, `sizeof`, structure fields), use the BUILD_BUG_ON() macro to ensure the condition is true.

```
BUILD_BUG_ON(sizeof(ctx->__reserved) != sizeof(reserved));
```

- If during compilation you have some warnings about unused variables/parameters, they must be fixed.
- Apply `checkpatch.pl --strict` when possible which might find some potential problems in your code.



Linux Kernel Debugging



Linux Kernel Debugging

- The Linux Kernel features multiple tools to ease kernel debugging:
  - A dedicated logging framework
  - A standard way to dump low level crash messages
  - Multiple runtime checkers to check for different kind of issues: memory issues, locking mistakes, undefined behaviors, etc.
  - Interactive or post-mortem debugging
- Many of those features need to be explicitly enabled in the kernel menuconfig, those are grouped in the `Kernel hacking -> Kernel debugging` menuconfig entry.
  - CONFIG_DEBUG_KERNEL should be set to "y" to enable other debug options.



Debugging using messages



Debugging/tracing using logs 1/4

- Good old printk()!
  - Works in all contexts
  - Can specify a log level ranging from `0` (emergency) to `7` (debug)
  - Be careful of the delays introduced when logs are printed out on a serial console at 115200 bauds
    - A `*_ratelimited()` version exists to limit the amount of print if called too often
  - Not recommended for upstream contributions

Example:

```
printk("in probe\n");
```

Here's what you get in the kernel log:

```
[    1.878382] in probe
```

All other logging facilities are based on it.



Debugging/tracing using logs 2/4

- The `pr_*()` family of functions
  - They include the log level in the name: pr_emerg(), pr_alert(), pr_crit(), pr_err(), pr_warn(), pr_notice(), pr_info(), pr_cont() and the special pr_debug() (see next pages)
  - They allow setting a manual prefix (eg. eases grepping):

```
#define pr_fmt(fmt) "foo: " fmt
```

- Also defined in include/linux/printk.h

Example:

```
pr_info("in probe\n");
```

Here's what you get in the kernel log:

```
[    1.878382] in probe
```

or similarly with a manual format:

```
[    1.878382] foo: in probe
```



Debugging/tracing using logs 3/4

- The `dev_*()` family of functions
  - They include a formatted standard prefix with the device name: dev_emerg(), dev_alert(), dev_crit(), dev_err(), dev_warn(), dev_notice(), dev_info() and the special dev_dbg() (see next pages)
  - They additionally take a pointer to struct device as first argument
  - Defined in include/linux/dev_printk.h
  - To be used in device drivers

Example:

```
dev_info(&pdev->dev, "in probe\n");
```

Here's what you get in the kernel log:

```
[    1.878382] serial 48024000.serial: in probe
[    1.884873] serial 481a8000.serial: in probe
```



Debugging/tracing using logs 4/4

- The kernel defines many more format specifiers than the standard `printf()` existing ones.
  - `%p`: Display the hashed value of pointer by default
  - `%px`: Always display the address of a pointer (use carefully on non-sensitive)
  - `%pK`: Display hashed pointer value, zeros or the pointer address depending on `kptr_restrict` sysctl value
  - `%pOF`: Device-tree node format specifier
  - `%pr`: Resource structure format specifier
  - `%pa`: Physical address display (work on all architectures 32/64 bits)
  - `%pe`: Error pointer (displays the string corresponding to the error number)
- See core-api/printk-formats for an exhaustive list of format specifiers
- Also features a helper to dump entire buffers with a `hexdump` like display: print_hex_dump()



pr_debug() and dev_dbg()

- When the driver is compiled with `DEBUG` defined, all these messages are compiled and printed at the debug level. `DEBUG` can be defined at the beginning of the driver, or using `ccflags-$(CONFIG_DRIVER) += -DDEBUG` in the `Makefile`
- When the kernel is compiled with CONFIG_DYNAMIC_DEBUG, then these messages can dynamically be enabled on a per-file, per-module or per-message basis, by writing commands to `/proc/dynamic_debug/control`. Note that messages are not enabled by default.
  - Details in admin-guide/dynamic-debug-howto
  - Very powerful feature to only get the debug messages you're interested in.
- When neither `DEBUG` nor CONFIG_DYNAMIC_DEBUG are used, these messages are not compiled in.



pr_debug() and dev_dbg() usage

- Debug prints can be enabled using the `/proc/dynamic_debug/control` file.
  - `cat /proc/dynamic_debug/control` will display all lines that can be enabled in the kernel
  - Example: `init/main.c:1427 [main]run_init_process =p " %s"`
- A syntax allows to enable individual print using lines, files or modules
  - `echo "file drivers/pinctrl/core.c +p" > /proc/dynamic_debug/control` will enable all debug prints in `drivers/pinctrl/core.c`
  - `echo "module pciehp +p" > /proc/dynamic_debug/control` will enable the debug print located in the `pciehp` module
  - `echo "file init/main.c line 1427 +p" > /proc/dynamic_debug/control` will enable the debug print located at line 1247 of file `init/main.c`
  - Replace `+p` with `-p` to disable the debug print



Debug logs troubleshooting

- When using dynamic debug, make sure that your debug call is enabled: it must be visible in `control` file in debugfs **and** be activated (`=p`)
- Is your log output only in the kernel log buffer?
  - You can see it thanks to `dmesg`
  - You can lower the `loglevel` to output it to the console directly
  - You can also set `ignore_loglevel` in the kernel command line to force all kernel logs to console
- If you are working on an out-of-tree module, you may prefer to define `DEBUG` in your module source or Makefile instead of using dynamic debug
- If configuration is done through the kernel command line, is it properly interpreted?
  - Starting from 5.14, kernel will let you know about faulty command line: `Unknown kernel command line parameters foo, will be passed to user space.`
  - You may need to take care of special characters escaping (e.g: quotes)
- Be aware that a few subsystems bring their own logging infrastructure, with specific configuration/controls, eg: `drm.debug=0x1ff`



Kernel early debug

- When booting, the kernel sometimes crashes even before displaying the system messages
- On ARM, if your kernel doesn't boot or hangs without any message, you can activate early debugging options
  - CONFIG_DEBUG_LL=y to enable ARM early serial output capabilities
  - CONFIG_EARLY_PRINTK=y will allow printk to output the prints earlier
- `earlyprintk` command line parameter should be given to enable early printk output

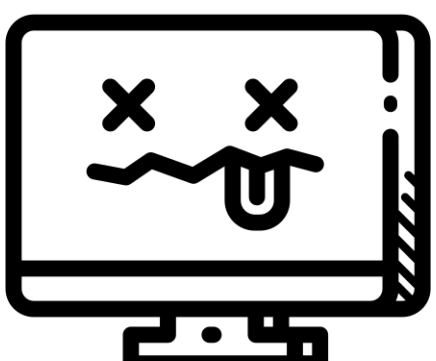


Kernel crashes and oops



Kernel crashes

- The kernel is not immune to crash, many errors can be done and lead to crashes
  - Memory access error (NULL pointer, out of bounds access, etc)
  - Voluntarily panicking on error detection (using panic())
  - Kernel incorrect execution mode (sleeping in atomic context)
  - Deadlocks detected by the kernel (Soft lockup/locking problem)
- On error, the kernel will display a message on the console that is called a “Kernel oops”



Icon by Peter van Driel, TheNounProject.com



Kernel oops (1/2)

- The content of this message depends on the architecture that is used.
- Almost all architectures display at least the following information:
  - CPU state when the oops happened
  - Registers content with potential interpretation
  - Backtrace of function calls that led to the crash
  - Stack content (last X bytes)
- Depending on the architecture, the crash location can be identified using the content of the PC registers (sometimes named IP, EIP, etc).
- To have a meaningful backtrace with symbol names use CONFIG_KALLSYMS=y which will embed the symbol names in the kernel image.



Kernel oops (2/2)

- Symbols are displayed in the backtrace using the following format:
  - `<symbol_name>+<hex_offset>/<symbol_size>`
- If the oops is not critical (taken in process context), then the kernel will kill process and continue its execution
  - The kernel stability might be compromised!
- Tasks that are taking too much time to execute and that are hung can also generate an oops (CONFIG_DETECT_HUNG_TASK)
- If KGDB support is present and configured, on oops, the kernel will switch to KGDB mode.

Oops example (1/2)

```
[    1.635909] 8<--- cut here ---
[    1.639034] Unable to handle kernel NULL pointer dereference at virtual address 00000050
[    1.647304] [00000050] *pgd=00000000
[    1.650959] Internal error: Oops: 5 [#1] SMP ARM
[    1.655635] Modules linked in:
[    1.658736] CPU: 0 PID: 28 Comm: kworker/u4:1 Not tainted 5.18.0-rc6-01642-g59dcbe02d20b #48
[    1.667261] Hardware name: Generic DT based system
[    1.672104] Workqueue: events_unbound deferred_probe_work_func
[    1.678029] PC is at miic_create+0xac/0x134
[    1.682280] LR is at _raw_spin_unlock_irqrestore+0x2c/0x34
[    1.687841] pc : [<804ba6e4>]    lr : [<806811f0>]    psr: 20000053
[    1.694172] sp : 90a99cf8  ip : 90a99cc8  fp : 90a99d1c
[    1.699453] r10: 8089339e  r9 : 808a5a18  r8 : 8fdb4284
[    1.704733] r7 : 82173000  r6 : 8fdb47d8  r5 : 82173010  r4 : 8fdb3ad8
[    1.711327] r3 : 00000000  r2 : 00000000  r1 : a0000053  r0 : 8fdb3ad8
[    1.717921] Flags: nzCv  IRQs on  FIQs off  Mode SVC_32  ISA ARM  Segment none
[    1.725220] Control: 10c5387d  Table: 8000406a  DAC: 00000051
[    1.731022] Register r0 information: non-slab/vmalloc memory
[    1.736754] Register r1 information: non-paged memory
[    1.741867] Register r2 information: NULL pointer
[    1.746629] Register r3 information: NULL pointer
[    1.751389] Register r4 information: non-slab/vmalloc memory
[    1.757113] Register r5 information: slab kmalloc-512 start 82173000 pointer offset 16 size 512
[    1.765943] Register r6 information: non-slab/vmalloc memory
[    1.771668] Register r7 information: slab kmalloc-512 start 82173000 pointer offset 0 size 512
[    1.780401] Register r8 information: non-slab/vmalloc memory
[    1.786125] Register r9 information: non-slab/vmalloc memory
[    1.791848] Register r10 information: non-slab/vmalloc memory
[    1.797661] Register r11 information: 2-page vmalloc region starting at 0x90a98000 allocated at kernel_clone+0xb4/0x2a4
[    1.808567] Register r12 information: 2-page vmalloc region starting at 0x90a98000 allocated at kernel_clone+0xb4/0x2a4
[    1.819468] Process kworker/u4:1 (pid: 28, stack limit = 0x(ptrval))
[    1.825889] Stack: (0x90a99cf8 to 0x90a9a000)
[    1.830304] 9ce0:                                                       00000005 ddf3fe37
[    1.838570] 9d00: 8259c840 8259c840 82173010 8fdb47d8 90a99dac 90a99d20 804bb7b8 804ba644
[    1.846834] 9d20: 00000000 90a99d34 00000002 8fdb46bc 00000000 8fdb4284 00000000 804f1c80
[    1.855099] 9d40: ffffffff 00000001 8089ad70 ffffffff 8fdb43f8 ff8fb728 ff8fb728 ddf3fe37
[    1.863364] 9d60: 82173010 82173010 81383ea0 82173010 00000002 8219cac0 90a99d9c ddf3fe37
[    1.871627] 9d80: 80458940 00000000 82173010 81383ea0 82173010 00000002 8219cac0 8200f00d
[    1.879892] 9da0: 90a99dcc 90a99db0 80449f44 804bb664 00000000 82173010 81383ea0 82173010
[    1.888155] 9dc0: 90a99dec 90a99dd0 80447cb8 80449ee8 82173010 81383ea0 81383ea0 82173010
[    1.896420] 9de0: 90a99e04 90a99df0 80447ef0 80447b9c 815b034c 815b0350 90a99e2c 90a99e08
[    1.904684] 9e00: 80447f54 80447e28 81383ea0 90a99e84 82173010 00000001 00000000 8219cac0
[    1.912948] 9e20: 90a99e4c 90a99e30 80448320 80447f10 00000000 90a99e84 8044827c 00000001
[    1.921213] 9e40: 90a99e7c 90a99e50 80445dac 80448288 82173010 82098e6c 82575ab8 ddf3fe37
[    1.929478] 9e60: 90a99e7c 82173010 8137c268 82173054 90a99eac 90a99e80 80448158 80445d00
[    1.937742] 9e80: 90a99eac 82173010 00000001 ddf3fe37 82173010 8137c268 82173010 8200f000
[    1.946006] 9ea0: 90a99ebc 90a99eb0 80448444 80448084 90a99edc 90a99ec0 80446c00 80448434
```

Cause and generic information

Register content and CPU state

Stack content



Oops example (2/2)

```
    2.036894] Backtrace:
    2.039380]  miic_create from a5psw_probe+0x160/0x3e0
    2.044530]  r6:8fdb47d8 r5:82173010 r4:8259c840
    2.049194]  a5psw_probe from platform_probe+0x68/0xb8
    2.054432]  r10:8200f00d r9:8219cac0 r8:00000002 r7:82173010 r6:81383ea0 r5:82173010
    2.062332]  r4:00000000
    2.064896]  platform_probe from really_probe+0x128/0x28c
    2.070383]  r7:82173010 r6:81383ea0 r5:82173010 r4:00000000
    2.076095]  really_probe from __driver_probe_device+0xd4/0xe8
    2.082018]  r7:82173010 r6:81383ea0 r5:81383ea0 r4:82173010
    2.087730]  __driver_probe_device from driver_probe_device+0x50/0xd0
    2.094260]  r5:815b0350 r4:815b034c
    2.097874]  driver_probe_device from __device_attach_driver+0xa4/0xc4
    2.104499]  r9:8219cac0 r8:00000000 r7:00000001 r6:82173010 r5:90a99e84 r4:81383ea0
    2.112309]  __device_attach_driver from bus_for_each_drv+0xb8/0xd0
    2.118677]  r7:00000001 r6:8044827c r5:90a99e84 r4:00000000
    2.124388]  bus_for_each_drv from __device_attach+0xe0/0x158
    2.130226]  r6:82173054 r5:8137c268 r4:82173010
    2.134881]  __device_attach from device_initial_probe+0x1c/0x20
    2.140977]  r7:8200f000 r6:82173010 r5:8137c268 r4:82173010
    2.146689]  device_initial_probe from bus_probe_device+0x38/0x90
    2.152869]  bus_probe_device from deferred_probe_work_func+0x90/0xa8
    2.159408]  r7:8200f000 r6:8137c1ec r5:8137c188 r4:82173010
    2.165121]  deferred_probe_work_func from process_one_work+0x1ac/0x278
    2.171839]  r7:8200f000 r6:82006800 r5:8137c1b0 r4:82180000
    2.177550]  process_one_work from process_scheduled_works+0x38/0x3c
    2.184011]  r10:90841e94 r9:81399b20 r8:8200681c r7:80d03d00 r6:82006800 r5:82180018
    2.191913]  r4:82180000
    2.194478]  process_scheduled_works from worker_thread+0x23c/0x2d4
    2.200840]  r5:82180018 r4:82180000
    2.204455]  worker_thread from kthread+0xd4/0xdc
    2.209254]  r9:82180000 r8:80131078 r7:821e2150 r6:821e2080 r5:821e2140 r4:8219cac0
    2.217065]  kthread from ret_from_fork+0x14/0x2c
    2.221842] Exception stack(0x90a99fb0 to 0x90a99ff8)
    2.226958] 9fa0:                                     00000000 00000000 00000000 00000000
    2.235220] 9fc0: 00000000 00000000 00000000 00000000 00000000 00000000 00000000 00000000
    2.243479] 9fe0: 00000000 00000000 00000000 00000000 00000013 00000000
    2.250170]  r10:00000000 r9:00000000 r8:00000000 r7:00000000 r6:00000000 r5:801373c4
    2.258074]  r4:821e2140 r3:00000001
    2.261704] Code: e3500000 0affffe6 e3a03000 e1a00004 (e5936050)
    2.267944] ---[ end trace 0000000000000000 ]---
```

Backtrace

Exception stack content



Kernel oops debugging: addr2line

- In order to convert addresses/symbol name from this display to source code lines, one can use addr2line
  - `addr2line -e vmlinux <address>`
- GNU binutils >= 2.39 takes the symbol+offset notation too:
  - `addr2line -e vmlinux <symbol_name>+<off>`
- The symbol+offset notation can be used with older binutils versions via the `faddr2line` script in the kernel sources:
  - `scripts/faddr2line vmlinux <symbol_name>+<off>`
- The kernel must have been compiled with CONFIG_DEBUG_INFO=y to embed the debugging information into the vmlinux file.



Kernel oops debugging: `decode_stacktrace.sh`

- `addr2line` decoding of oopses can be automated using `decode_stacktrace.sh` script which is provided in the kernel sources.
- This script will translate all symbol names/addresses to the matching file/lines and will display the assembly code where the crash did trigger.
- ```
  ./scripts/decode_stacktrace.sh vmlinux [linux_source_path/] \
  < oops_report.txt > decoded_oops.txt
  ```
- NOTE: `CROSS_COMPILE` and `ARCH` env var should be set to obtain the correct disassembly dump.
  ```



Panic and oops behavior configuration

- Sometimes, crash might be so bad that the kernel will panic and halt its execution entirely by stopping scheduling application and staying in a busy loop.
- Automatic reboot on panic can be enabled via CONFIG_PANIC_TIMEOUT
  - 0: never reboots
  - Negative value: reboot immediately
  - Positive value: seconds to wait before rebooting
- OOPS can be configured to always panic:
  - at boot time, adding `oops=panic` to the command line
  - at build time, setting CONFIG_PANIC_ON_OOPS=y